



Program Solicitation

Area-Multiplied Photonic-crystal Enhanced Devices
(AMPED)

Microsystems Technology Office

DARPA-PS-26-119

May 8, 2026

OVERVIEW INFORMATION:

- **Federal Agency Name:** Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA), Microsystems Technology Office (MTO)
- **Funding Opportunity Title:** Area-Multiplied Photonic-crystal Enhanced Devices (AMPED)
- **Solicitation Type:** Initial solicitation
- **Funding Opportunity Number:** DARPA-PS-26-119
- **Eligibility:** Participation in the AMPED Program is restricted to U.S. Citizens and U.S. Permanent Residents (Green Card holders) representing U.S. companies only.
- **Assistance Listing Number:** Not applicable
- **Dates/Time: All Times are Eastern Time Zone (ET)**
 - Posting Date: May 8, 2026
 - Proposers Day: May 13, 2026
 - Abstract Due Date: June 4, 2026, at 1:00 p.m.
 - Requests for CUI Materials Closed: June 4, 2026, at 1:00 p.m.
 - Question Submittal Closed: June 25, 2026, at 1:00 p.m.
 - Deadline to Submit Intent to Propose: June 25, 2026, at 1:00 p.m.
 - Proposal Due Date: July 9, 2026, at 1:00 p.m.
 - Anticipated Virtual Oral Presentation Dates: July 27, 2026, to August 7, 2026
- **Anticipated Individual Awards:** Multiple awards are anticipated.
- **Anticipated Funding:** \$39M for Phase 1 Technology Feasibility
\$14M for Phase 2 System Enablement
- **Proposer Requirements:** Proposers, including all proposed team members, are required to comply with regulations applicable to receiving and storing controlled unclassified information (CUI) material in accordance with:
 - Department of Defense Instruction (DoDI) 5200.48, “Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI)”
 - National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) Special Publication (SP) 800-171 (Rev 2), “Protecting Controlled Unclassified Information in Nonfederal Systems and Organizations”
- **Types of Instruments That May Be Awarded:** Other Transaction for Prototype Agreements under 10 U.S.C. 4022
- **NAICS Code:** 541715

- **Agency Contact:**

The PS Coordinator for this effort may be reached at:

AMPED@darpa.mil

DARPA/MTO

ATTN: DARPA-PS-26-119

675 North Randolph Street

Arlington, VA 22203-2114

**Program Solicitation
DARPA-PS-26-119**

**Area-Multiplied Photonic-crystal Enhanced Devices (AMPED)
Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA)
Microsystems Technology Office (MTO)**

Section I: Funding Opportunity Description

The Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) is soliciting innovative research proposals for the Area-Multiplied Photonic-crystal Enhanced Devices (AMPED) program. The goal of AMPED is to demonstrate single-mode, diffraction-limited, continuous-wave (CW), highly efficient laser devices capable of unprecedented output power in a chip-scale form factor. This represents orders-of-magnitude improvement over the current state of the art in single-mode photonic-crystal surface-emitting laser (PCSEL) devices.¹ This solicitation includes a controlled unclassified information (CUI) Addendum that contains key technical details relevant to the program goals and objectives.

Please see Attachment A of this PS for instructions on how to request the CUI Addendum.

A. Background

High-energy lasers (HELs) have the potential to unlock immense capability for applications including air defense, airborne self-protection, precision strike, and industrial materials processing. However, current HEL systems struggle to achieve the required power, beam quality, and low size, weight, and power (SWaP) needed for broad deployment across Department of War (DoW) platforms. This is because the underlying laser source technologies are typically confined by physical and architectural limitations that prevent significant scaling.

Today's most powerful semiconductor lasers, such as edge-emitting lasers (EELs) and vertical-cavity surface-emitting lasers (VCSELs), are limited to single-mode power levels of only a few watts. While these devices offer advantages in manufacturability and integration, they are deeply constrained by their 1D scaling physics; the requirement for the optical cavity to physically overlap the gain medium prevents transverse scaling beyond a few microns without the emergence of unwanted higher-order modes that degrade beam quality. This has forced the field toward complex, bulky, and inefficient solutions like spectral and coherent beam combination of many individual emitters, which significantly increases system SWaP and complexity, hindering proliferation.

A new laser device architecture, the photonic-crystal surface-emitting laser (PCSEL), offers a path forward by physically decoupling the gain medium from the optical cavity. This decoupling has led to state-of-the-art demonstrations producing up to 50 W of single-mode power.² However, even these advanced devices face hard scaling limits related to the emergence of higher-order modes and energy loss as device size increases, manifesting in two technical challenges:

¹ Noda *et al.*, *Advances in Optics and Photonics*, Vol. 15, No. 4, page 977, December 2023.

Technical Challenge 1 (TC1): Area scaling for single-mode emission

Lateral area scaling should theoretically result in a quadratic increase of laser device output power. However, as the device diameter increases, the gain margin between the desired fundamental mode and the nearest competing higher-order modes collapses. This mode competition, which is dictated by physical limits of the 2D photonic crystal, makes it progressively harder to maintain single-mode operation as the device size increases. In practical terms, this means the laser cannot be stabilized with ideal beam quality under normal operating conditions beyond a few millimeters in diameter.

Technical Challenge 2 (TC2): Maximizing power density by minimizing loss

In addition to lateral area scaling, device power can also be increased by scaling the optical output power density. However, this is constrained by optical and electrical loss mechanisms that reduce power conversion efficiency. Vertical stacking of gain regions, a successful technique in other laser technologies, is not easy to implement because the required tunnel junctions between gain regions introduce substantial free-carrier absorption, offsetting the added gain. Additionally, unpumped regions of the device near its edge act as perfect absorbers of laterally traveling photons, creating another significant loss channel. In the current design framework, there are not enough degrees of freedom to simultaneously add gain and mitigate these critical losses.

Today, these challenges are handled with incremental modifications to existing PCSEL photonic crystal designs, such as utilizing complex, multi-feature unit cells. While these efforts have yielded improvements that lead to today's state of the art, their benefit is beginning to exhibit diminishing returns, as they do not change the underlying scaling behavior that limits single-mode performance as device emitter area increases. It has become apparent that existing approaches cannot provide a pathway to substantially higher power without sacrificing beam quality. The key to addressing these two technical challenges is to redirect the community's efforts toward a comprehensive redesign of the device architecture that leverages all three dimensions for expanded design flexibility.

B. Program Description

AMPED aims to catalyze a new generation of HEL capabilities by creating a scalable, manufacturable, chip-scale laser source with high single-mode performance. The program seeks to revolutionize laser technology by shifting the design focus from incremental improvements on existing architectures to holistic device-level innovation where intrinsic scaling barriers are overcome.

To effectively enable this vision, AMPED seeks to emphasize three pillars: (1) architectural innovation, by moving beyond minor modifications of existing designs to re-engineering the device; (2) manufacturability, by leveraging established semiconductor fabrication processes to ensure a path to high-yield, high-volume production; and (3) domestic production, by prioritizing the use of U.S.-based foundry and manufacturing capabilities to create a sustainable and secure domestic supply chain.

All proposers should focus on developing a comprehensive device architecture that directly addresses the program's two technical challenges across the two phases. Proposed technical approaches will be evaluated based on the merit of their strategies to overcome the physics limiting current devices and the projected performance against the program's specific quantitative metrics (provided in the CUI Addendum), supported by physics-based simulation.

The efforts under AMPED are directed at device-level innovation as opposed to system-level beam combining or incremental component improvement. Specifically discouraged are technical approaches that solely pursue minor variations of existing PCSEL designs. Instead, proposers should focus on holistic device redesigns that may exploit new degrees of freedom in all three dimensions. Proposers are expected to have access to device modeling and simulation tools sufficient for designing and validating their proposed architecture. Development of new modeling/simulation tools should not be the central focus of the proposed effort.

C. Program Structure

The AMPED program is a 42-month effort structured into two distinct phases: a 24-month Phase 1 and an 18-month Phase 2. Proposals must address the program goals in their entirety and include both Phase 1 and Phase 2. Performers who demonstrate early, verifiable achievement of Phase 1 hardware milestones and metrics may be authorized to initiate Phase 2 activities prior to the completion of Phase 1, allowing concurrent execution. Otherwise, Phase 2 may commence after completion of Phase 1. Phase 2 is not guaranteed and may be authorized by the Government through a modification based on demonstrated technical achievements, including performance against program metrics and the overall value of results. This programmatic flexibility is designed to transition breakthrough HEL technologies to system demonstration as rapidly as technical maturity allows.

Phase 1: Technology Feasibility (24 months)

The goal of Phase 1 is to retire the highest technical risks and establish a viable path to the final program goals. Success in the first phase will be marked by the demonstration of robust devices, delivered to the Government as hardware deliverables and tested by independent verification and validation (IV&V), that achieve the program's Phase 1 metrics. Performers are expected to begin work on thermal management strategies (to include packaging) at the program onset to support the anticipated needs for end of Phase 1 devices.

Phase 2: System Enablement (18 months)

The goal of Phase 2 is to mature validated device designs from Phase 1 and to enable system-level capability. The final program objective is to produce chip-scale laser devices that achieve the program's Phase 2 metrics, representing a transformative improvement over the state of the art. Success in Phase 2 will be demonstrated through delivery of hardware and IV&V confirming that the devices meet the program's overall metrics.

Performance Challenges

The AMPED program includes competitive Performance Challenges to accelerate the realization of breakthrough technical performance outcomes. For each challenge, only the first performer to achieve verifiable results meeting the defined criteria will receive an incentive payment. Performance Challenge criteria are provided in Table 1 of the AMPED CUI Addendum.

The first performer to meet the challenge criteria, as verified by the Government through IV&V, will receive a fixed incentive payment of \$250,000, subject to the availability of funds.

If no performer meets the challenge criteria by the due date provided in Table 1 of the AMPED CUI Addendum, no incentive payment will be made. Only one incentive payment will be made per Performance Challenge. A single performer may receive incentive payments for multiple Performance Challenges; incentive payments are cumulative across challenges.

The Government will determine whether the challenge criteria have been met and the order of achievement. In the event of substantially simultaneous achievement, the Government will determine the awardee based on the earliest received deliverable to the IV&V team. The Government's determination is final.

D. Schedule, Milestones, and Deliverables

A summary of the program schedule is presented in Figure 1. For planning and budgetary purposes only, proposers should assume an estimated program start date of October 1, 2026.

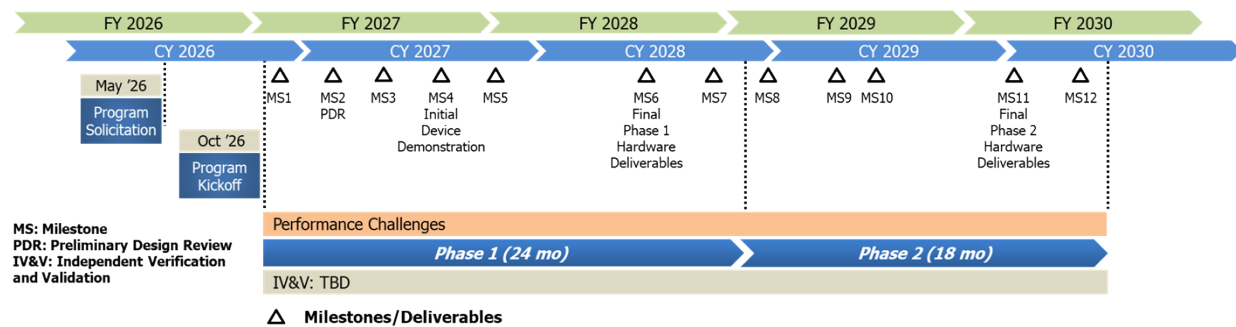


Figure 1. AMPED program schedule

All proposals must include the following meetings and travel in the proposed schedule and costs:

- To foster collaboration between teams and disseminate program developments, a 2-day Principal Investigator (PI) meeting will be held approximately every 12 months. For budgeting purposes, plan for two 2-day meetings per program phase, which will generally be held in the Washington, D.C. area.
- Regular teleconference meetings will be scheduled with the Government team for progress reporting as well as problem identification and mitigation. Proposers should also anticipate at least one site visit per phase by the DARPA Program Manager, during which they will have the opportunity to demonstrate progress towards agreed-upon milestones.

A summary of the required program milestones and deliverables by phase is presented in Table 1 and Table 2.

Table 1. Program Milestones and Deliverables for Phase 1

Milestone	Due Date (Months after award)	Deliverable/Exit Criteria	Milestone Payment Allocation (%) *
1. Initial Program Execution Plan, CUI Readiness, and Kick-off	1	Deliverables: - Initial program execution plan describing design, fabrication, and characterization methodologies - Physics device model projecting electro-optical performance and path to meeting program metrics - Thermal management approach and model - Resource Commitment Evidence Package - Report on CUI information systems compliance Exit Criteria: - Kick-off meeting completed with follow-up actions/revisions addressed - Government approval of program execution plan, electro-optical physics model, and thermal management approach - Government concurrence with CUI compliance status	5%
2. Phase 1 Preliminary Design Review (PDR)	4	Deliverables: - PDR technical package for AMPED device outlining physical design, fabrication plan, operating conditions, test plan, and projected performance - Documentation supporting compliance with NIST SP 800-171 Rev 2 and demonstrating that information systems meet the required standards for handling and protecting AMPED CUI.** Exit Criteria: - PDR successfully completed with follow-up actions/revisions addressed - Government approval of PDR technical package - CUI compliance achieved	15%
3. Device Fabrication Plan	6	Deliverables: - Device fabrication report - Risk mitigation report Exit Criteria: - Government acceptance of fabrication and risk reporting	10%

4. Initial device demonstration	10	Deliverables: - On-site performer device demonstration to Government and IV&V team - On-site performer demonstration of thermal management approach - Reporting on initial device experimental results - Experimental vs. simulation comparison and revised design strategies to achieve the Phase 1 metrics Exit Criteria: - Site visit to performer demo completed - Review with Government on initial device results with follow-up actions/revisions addressed - Government approval of revised design strategies	15%
5. Device Design Improvement and Annual PI review	13	Deliverables: - Annual PI meeting presentation with DARPA - Revised program execution plan, device design improvements, and projected performance plan. Exit Criteria: - Annual PI meeting completed with follow-up actions/revisions addressed - Government approval of revised program execution plan, device design improvements and projected performance plan.	15%
6. Phase 1 Prototype Demonstration and Delivery	20	Deliverables: - Prototype: 4 packaged*** parts and test plan to the Government IV&V team for evaluation - Report on hardware experimental characterization - Prototype: Experimental demonstration of device performance that meets Phase 1 metrics Exit Criteria: - Government acceptance of all Deliverables - Review with DARPA on results is completed with follow-up actions/revisions addressed	20%
7. End of Phase 1	23	Deliverables: - Final Phase 1 written report that details optimized device design, fabrication procedure, test plan, characterization results, and recommended future work - Final Phase 1 presentation summarizing optimized device design, fabrication procedure, test plan, characterization results, and recommended future work Exit Criteria: - All Phase 1 quarterly progress report (QPR) meetings with DARPA are completed - Government acceptance of all Deliverables with follow-up actions/revisions addressed	20%

* Use as guidance for an approximate allocation of funds in phase 1. Allocation amounts are based on careful consideration of the technical value of the milestone deliverable to the Government as well as the time, effort, and resources necessary to complete each milestone.

** Performers may not be funded for subsequent milestones beyond Milestone 2 if they have not demonstrated the ability to handle and protect AMPED CUI.

*** To ensure alignment with Government test infrastructure and to enable rigorous independent verification and validation (IV&V), the performers' detailed mechanical, electrical, and thermal-management packaging approaches will be defined and refined in coordination with the Government IV&V team during the first quarter following Phase 1 program kickoff. The Government IV&V team will release the packaging specifications, and performers will incorporate these Government-provided requirements into all packaging, cooling, and integration plans upon issuance.

Table 2. Program Milestones and Deliverables for Phase 2

Milestone	Due Date (Months after award)	Deliverable/Exit Criteria	Milestone Payment Allocation (%) *
8. Phase 2 Execution Plan, Model Plan, and Kick-off	25	Deliverables: - Phase 2 program execution plan describing design, fabrication, and characterization methodologies - Physics device model projecting electro-optical performance and path to meeting Phase 2 program metrics - Thermal management approach and model plan Exit Criteria: - Phase 2 kick-off meeting completed with follow-up actions/revisions addressed - Government approval of program execution plan, electro-optical physics model, and thermal management approach	10%
9. Phase 2 Revised device design review	28	Deliverables: - Revised device design technical package for AMPED device outlining physical design, fabrication plan, operating conditions, test plan, and projected performance Exit Criteria: - Revised device design review successfully completed - All review action items resolved or dispositioned - Government approval of revised design technical package	20%
10. Device Fabrication Plan	30	Deliverables: - Device fabrication report and risk mitigation plan Exit Criteria: - Government acceptance of all Deliverables	15%
11. Phase 2 Prototype Demonstration and Delivery	39	Deliverables: - Prototype: Delivery of 8 packaged*** parts and test plan to the Government IV&V team for evaluation - Report on deliverable experimental characterization - Prototype: Experimental demonstration of device performance Exit Criteria: - Government acceptance of all Deliverables - Review with DARPA on results is completed with follow-up actions/revisions addressed	30%

12. End of Phase 2	42	Deliverables: • Phase 2 Final program written report that details optimized device design, fabrication procedure, test plan, characterization results, and recommended future work • Phase 2 Final program presentation summarizing optimized device design, fabrication procedure, test plan, characterization results, and recommended future work Exit Criteria: • All quarterly progress report (QPR) meetings with DARPA are completed • Government acceptance of all Deliverables	25%
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* Use as guidance for an approximate allocation of funds in Phase 2.

** To ensure alignment with Government test infrastructure and to enable rigorous independent verification and validation (IV&V), the performers' detailed mechanical, electrical, and thermal-management packaging approaches will be defined and refined in coordination with the Government IV&V team during the first quarter following Phase 2 program kickoff. The Government IV&V team will release the packaging specifications, and performers will incorporate these Government-provided requirements into all packaging, cooling, and integration plans upon issuance.

E. Government Furnished Equipment/Property/Information

No Government furnished equipment, property, or information is anticipated in this program.

F. License Rights and Technical Data

The Government requires **no less than Government purpose rights** in all Foreground Data developed or generated under the program and related to the proposed prototype capability or operational utility of the proposed effort.

For Background Data to be delivered to the Government and necessary for the Government to use, evaluate, integrate, transition, or fully operate the proposed prototype capability or deliverables, the Government requires the right, solely for Government purposes, to use, reproduce, modify, analyze, evaluate, display, and disclose such data to support Government use, evaluation, integration, and transition.

For the purposes of this PS, the following definitions apply:

- **Background Data:** Data developed outside the scope of any resulting agreement from this solicitation and identified as Background Data by the proposer.
- **Data:** Recorded information, regardless of form or method of recording, which includes, but is not limited to, technical data, software, mask works, and trade secrets. The term does not include financial, administrative, cost, pricing, or management information and does not include inventions.
- **Foreground Data:** Data first generated, developed, produced, or modified in the performance of work under any resulting agreement from this solicitation, including modifications, enhancements, derivatives, configurations, or trained models or outputs derived from Background Data to the extent such work is performed under the resulting agreement.
- **Government purpose:** any activity in which the United States Government is a party or has a direct interest. Government purposes include activities supporting Government use, evaluation,

integration, testing, and transition. Government purposes do not include commercial use or authorization of such use.

- Government purpose rights: the rights to use, reproduce, modify, analyze, evaluate, display, and disclose Data, in whole or in part and in any manner, for Government purposes only, and to authorize others to do so for Government purposes only.

Section II: Evaluation Criteria

- Proposals will be evaluated using the following criteria listed in **descending order of importance**: Overall Scientific and Technical Merit; Potential Contribution and Relevance to the DARPA Mission; and Budget and Price.
 - **Overall Scientific and Technical Merit:** The proposed technical approach is innovative, feasible, achievable, and complete. The proposed technical team has the expertise and experience to accomplish the proposed tasks. Task descriptions and associated technical elements provided are complete and in a logical sequence with all proposed deliverables clearly defined such that a final outcome that achieves the program goals can be expected as a result of award. The proposal identifies major technical risks and planned mitigation efforts are clearly defined and feasible.
 - **Potential Contribution and Relevance to the DARPA Mission:** The potential contributions of the proposed effort bolster the national security technology base and support DARPA's mission to create and prevent technological surprise. The proposed data right assertions (if any) will not significantly impact the Government's ability to transition the technology. The proposed Data Rights will not restrict or otherwise impair the Government's ability, for Government purposes, to use, reproduce, modify, analyze, evaluate, display, or disclose such data, or to transition the technology.
 - **Budget and Price:** The proposed solution is realistic and affordable. The budget is realistic and accurately reflects the technical goals and objectives of the solicitation and reflects a sufficient understanding of the level of effort and staffing needed to successfully accomplish the proposed technical approach. Each price element provides commensurate technical, schedule, or execution value, and is it necessary, appropriately scaled, and neither materially overestimated nor underestimated.

Section III: Submission Information

- This Program Solicitation (PS) may result in the award of Other Transaction (OT) for Prototype agreements, which can include not only commercially available technologies fueled by commercial or strategic investment, but also concept demonstrations, pilots, and agile development activities that can incrementally improve commercial technologies, existing Government-owned capabilities, and/or concepts for broad defense and/or public application(s). Follow-on production contracts or transactions may also be awarded pursuant to 10 U.S.C. § 4022. The OT agreement will not require cost sharing unless the offeror is a traditional defense contractor who is not working with a nontraditional defense contractor participating in the program to a significant extent. The following websites are incorporated by reference and contain additional information regarding overall proposer instructions, general terms and conditions, and Other Transactions for Prototype.
 - **Proposer Instructions and General Terms and Conditions:** [Proposer Instructions and General Terms and Conditions](#)
 - **Other Transaction agreements:** [Proposer Instructions: Other Transactions](#)
- **Abstract:** Submission of an abstract is required to be eligible to submit a full proposal. Abstracts must be submitted no later than the due date and time stated in the Overview section and must conform to the instructions and templates in **Attachment B**. For additional guidance, see Section V-D.
- **Virtual Oral Presentation:** Pre-recorded presentations, videos, voice recordings, narrated slide decks, or other prerecorded media are not permitted.
- **Notification of Intent to Propose:** Proposers must submit a notification of intent to propose by the due date and time stated in the Overview section to support scheduling of virtual oral presentations. Failure to do so may place your team at a significant administrative disadvantage and result in lower scheduling priority and delays in the evaluation process.

Notifications of intent to propose must be submitted by email to AMPED@darpa.mil and include:

- Statement of intent to propose.
- Abstract control number.
- Prime organization and their Principal Investigators (PI) and Co-Principal Investigators (Co-PIs).
- Subcontractor organizations and their PIs and Co-PIs.
- Statement indicating which Key Personnel (prime and subcontractor PIs and Co-PIs) or oral presentation attendees have submitted a DARPA eForm 60.
 - **Any Key Personnel or individual participating in the virtual oral presentation who is a U.S. Permanent Resident (i.e., Green Card holder) or foreign national must submit a DARPA eForm 60 no later than the notification of intent due date via <https://dtsn.darpa.mil/eform60/>. Failure to submit may result in denial of participation in the oral presentation or the program.**
 - **The prime is responsible for ensuring all personnel, including sub-awardees, comply with these requirements**

- **Proposal:** Full proposals are due no later than the due date and time stated in the Overview section. **Attachments C, D, E, F, G, H, and I** contain specific instructions and templates and constitute a full proposal submission. For instructions and guidance on submitting proposals, see Section V-D.
- DARPA is interested in whether, and to what extent, proposers are using artificial intelligence (AI) tools to contribute to Volume 1 of proposals submitted in response to DARPA solicitations. Therefore, proposers must answer the following questions on the cover sheet of Volume 1 of this solicitation:
 - Did you use AI tools to assist in preparing this proposal?
 - If yes, what tools did you employ?

Any content in Volume 1 that utilized an AI tool to generate information, assist in technical understanding, or guide the technical work should have a citation and a corresponding reference in the Bibliography section of Volume 1. The citation should specify the tool, content, and purpose. For example, “[AI tool] was used to understand existing state of the art in manufacturing.”

NOTE – THIS INFORMATION WILL NOT BE USED FOR EVALUATION PURPOSES. Proposals will be evaluated in accordance with the Evaluation Criteria outlined in the solicitation regardless of whether AI tools were employed.

- **PS Attachments:**
 - **Attachment A:** AMPED CUI Materials Request Form
 - **Attachment B:** Abstract Instructions and Template
 - **Attachment C:** Proposal Summary Slide Template
 - **Attachment D:** Proposal Instructions and Volume I Template (Technical and Management)
 - **Attachment E:** Proposal Instructions and Volume II Template (Price)
 - **Attachment F:** DARPA Price Summary Spreadsheet
 - **Attachment G:** Other Transaction Certification Template
 - **Attachment H:** Task Description Document (TDD) Template
 - **Attachment I:** Schedule of Milestones and Payments
 - **Attachment J:** Model Other Transaction for Prototype
 - **(informational) Attachment K:** AMPED Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) Guide signed April 23, 2026
 - **(informational) Attachment L:** DARPA BAAT Submission Portal Guide
- All technical, contractual, and administrative questions regarding this notice must be emailed to AMPED@darpa.mil. Emails sent directly to the Program Manager or any other address may result in delayed or no response. All questions must be in English and must include the name, email address, and telephone number of a point of contact. DARPA will attempt to answer all questions in a timely manner and post an FAQ list on the DARPA/MTO Opportunities page at (<http://www.darpa.mil/work-with-us/opportunities>). The list will be updated on an ongoing basis until one week prior to the proposal due date.

Section IV: Security Information

- This program is subject to **Attachment K: AMPED Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) Guide** signed April 23, 2026. All individuals accessing CUI agree to protect CUI in accordance with *DoD Instruction 5200.48 CONTROLLED UNCLASSIFIED INFORMATION (CUI)* and *NIST Special Publication 800-171 Rev 2 Protecting Controlled Unclassified Information in Nonfederal Systems and Organizations*.

- **Unclassified Submission Requirements**

Proposers are responsible for preventing the inclusion of any CUI in proposals marked as Unclassified. This responsibility includes ensuring that unauthorized personnel and non-accredited information systems are not used in the preparation of the proposal.

- **CUI Proposal Marking**

If an Unclassified submission contains CUI or the suspicion of such, as defined by Executive Order 13556 and 32 CFR Part 2002, the information must be appropriately and conspicuously marked CUI in accordance with DoDI 5200.48. Identification of what is CUI about this DARPA program will be detailed in Attachment K: AMPED Controlled Unclassified Information Guide (CUIG) signed April 23, 2026.

- **CUI Submission Requirements**

For Unclassified proposals containing CUI, applicants will ensure personnel and information systems processing CUI are in accordance with DoDI 5200.48 and NIST SP 800-171 Rev 2

Unclassified submissions containing CUI may be submitted via DARPA's BAA Website (<https://baa.darpa.mil>) in accordance with Section III and Section IV of this PS.

- **Classified Submissions**

DARPA anticipates that submissions received under this PS will be at least CUI. However, should a proposer wish to submit classified information, an unclassified email must be sent to AMPED@darpa.mil notifying the MTO Program Security Officer.

Security classification guidance and direction via a Security Classification Guide (SCG) and/or DD Form 254, "DoD Contract Security Classification Specification," will not be provided at this time. If a determination is made that the award instrument may result in access to classified information, a SCG and/or DD Form 254 will be issued by DARPA and attached as part of the award.

Performers who wish to propose classified solutions should contact AMPED@darpa.mil for further instructions. Included within the request to share classified information should be, if possible, the level of information, information owner, disposition system, and a point of contact for further instructions.

Section V: Special Considerations

A. General Information

- This solicitation, stated attachments, and websites incorporated by reference constitute the entire solicitation. **In the event of a discrepancy between solicitation, attachments, or websites, the solicitation shall take precedence.**

B. Eligibility

- Non-U.S. organizations and/or individuals cannot participate in this solicitation. All other responsible sources capable of satisfying the Government's needs may submit a proposal that shall be considered by DARPA. Historically Black Colleges and Universities, Small Businesses, Small Disadvantaged Businesses, and Minority Institutions are encouraged to submit proposals and join others in submitting proposals; however, no portion of this solicitation will be set aside for these organizations' participation due to the impracticality of reserving discrete or severable areas of this research for exclusive competition among these entities.
- DARPA encourages technical solutions from all responsible sources capable of satisfying the Government's needs. To ensure fair competition across the ecosystem, DARPA prohibits contractors/performers from concurrently providing Systems Engineering Technical Assistance (SETA), Advisory and Assistance Services (A&AS), or similar support services and being a technical performer, unless the DARPA Deputy Director grants a written waiver.
- Federally Funded Research and Development Centers (FFRDCs), University Affiliated Research Centers (UARCs), and Government Entities to include National Laboratories are not eligible to propose to this solicitation.
- Only proposals from organizations that have requested and been provided the AMPED CUI Addendum will be considered. The CUI Addendum contains CUI and will be released only upon completion of the required access forms and verification of applicable security requirements. Proposals from organizations not provided the CUI Addendum will not be considered.
- Only proposals from organizations that submitted a timely, compliant abstract in accordance with this solicitation will be considered.

C. Research Type

- This program has been determined by the Government to be **non-fundamental research**. Proposals premised on the performance of fundamental research will not be considered. As a result, work performed under any resulting agreement will be subject to restrictions on the release and disclosure of information. Awardees must obtain prior written Government approval before publishing, releasing, or otherwise disclosing any information or results generated under this program. For additional information on Publication Restrictions and Public Release Requirements for Non-Fundamental Research, please refer to [Proposer Instructions and General Terms and Conditions](#).

The Government retains sole discretion to determine the applicability of this non-fundamental research designation. Appropriate language will be included in resultant awards to prescribe publication requirements and other restrictions.

D. <https://www.nsf.gov/bfa/dias/policy/nsfm-33-implementation-guidance><https://www.darpa.mil/about/offices/contracts-management/proposer-transactions> Submission Instructions and Guidance

- Abstract and proposals must be submitted through the Broad Agency Announcement Tool (BAAT) at <https://baa.darpa.mil>. <https://www.darpa.mil/work-with-us/proposer-instructions> Instructions for BAAT account creation are provided in Attachment L. Note that accounts are disabled after a period of 30 days of inactivity (i.e., not logging in). Email submissions will not be considered. Proposers are encouraged to submit at least 48 hours prior to the due date. Late submissions will not be accepted.

E. Additional Information

- The APEX Accelerators program, formerly known as the Procurement Technical Assistance Program (PTAP), focuses on building a strong, sustainable, and resilient U.S. supply chains by assisting a wide range of businesses that pursue and perform under contracts with the DoW, other federal agencies, state and local governments, and with Government prime contractors. See <https://www.apexaccelerators.us/> for more information. APEX Accelerators helps businesses:
 - Complete registration with a wide range of databases necessary for them to participate in the Government marketplace (e.g., SAM)
 - Identify which agencies and offices may need their products or services and how connect with buying agencies and offices
 - Determine whether they are ready for Government opportunities and how to position themselves to succeed
 - Navigate solicitations and potential funding opportunities
 - Receive notifications of Government contract opportunities on a regular basis
 - Network with buying officers, prime contractors, and other businesses
 - Resolve performance issues and prepare for audit, only if the service is needed, after receiving an award
- Project Spectrum is a nonprofit effort funded by the DoD Office of Small Business Programs to help educate the Defense Industrial Base (DIB) on compliance. Project Spectrum is vendor-neutral and available to assist businesses with their cybersecurity and compliance needs. Their mission is to improve cybersecurity readiness, resilience, and compliance for small/medium-sized businesses and the federal manufacturing supply chain. Project Spectrum events and programs will enhance awareness of cybersecurity threats within the manufacturing, research, and development, as well as knowledge-based services sectors of the industrial base. Project Spectrum will leverage strategic partnerships within and outside of the DoD to accelerate the overall cybersecurity compliance of the DIB. www.Projectspectrum.io is a web portal that will provide resources such as individualized dashboards, a marketplace, and Pilot Program to help accelerate cybersecurity compliance.
- DARPAConnect offers free resources to potential performers to help them navigate DARPA, including “Understanding DARPA Award Vehicles and Solicitations,” “Making the Most of Proposers Days,” and “Tips for DARPA Proposal Success.” Join DARPAConnect at <https://www.darpaconnect.us> to leverage on-demand learning and networking resources.

- DARPA has streamlined our Program Solicitations and is interested in your feedback on this new format. Please send any comments to DARPA solicitations@darpa.mil.